



OPEN EMBRACE: Kulkarni (centre) at a shelter

tor. "It was a time when graduates from IITs were being invited to work and tribute their professional talent in the development sector," he says. This is Kulkarni, who was till then developing to improve irrigation techniques in the Krishna belt, started Sathi in Raichur, North Karnataka.

Sathi is not a home for rescued children and Kulkarni is very clear about it. It only serves as an intermediate shelter before the child is sent home and the process usually takes 15 days. Children, who have been on the platform for more than a couple of months, are not sent to the regular shelter. They are sent to rehabilitation camps, where their addictions and other problems are addressed before they are reunited with their families. Of the children who are rescued and rehabilitated, about 20 per cent with delinquent behaviour run away from their families and land up on the platform again. "The sooner a child is rescued the better. If a child is on the platform for more than a few weeks, it will absorb the child," he says. The platform becomes a world of adventure, of hardship and survival. A child doesn't remain a child anymore. He or she gets sucked into a life of disease, crime, gangs and, worst of all, substance abuse. Nearly 30 per cent of rescued children belong to this category.

Not all stories have happy endings. Kulkarni is aware of the fact. "It breaks my heart, when we have children whose homes cannot be located, others who are mentally challenged and still others who have no homes to go to. These children have to be sent to homes—run either by the government or private bodies—that take care of them, while the fortunate ones go back to where they belong," he says.

The search for funds is a constant endeavour for Kulkarni while launching professionals is a big constraint for the organisation. "We don't get people who are masters in social work. We get those who don't get jobs elsewhere. But we train them and have learnt to manage," he says. Funding has come from varied sources, among them the Sir Ratan Tata Trust, Infosys Foundation and an association in the UK that supports children in railway stations.

What keeps the Sathi workers going is the joy of the parents who are reunited with their children. "In fact, these events are so intense that I don't attend them anymore," says a visibly-overwhelmed Kulkarni.